

NO TO HINDI Members of student organisations protest against NEP 2020 in Chennai, Feb. 28

ANI

will be imposed on any state. The three languages learned by children will be the choices of states, regions, and of course the students themselves, so long as at least two of the three languages are native to India," reads the relevant part of the policy. That is, in addition to the state's language, children would be required to learn at least one other Indian language—not necessarily Hindi. "There is absolutely no imposition of any language on any state or community. NEP 2020 upholds linguistic freedom, ensuring students have the autonomy to learn in the language of their choice," says Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

BJP Tamil Nadu chief K. Annamalai has also questioned the DMK's stance. "Private schools attended by the children and grandchildren of DMK leaders follow a trilingual policy. Shouldn't government school students have the same opportunities?" he asked, emphasising the perceived contradiction in the DMK's opposition to the policy while allowing elite institutions in the state to follow the same trilingual approach.

Yet Stalin and DMK leaders remain staunch in their opposition. Emphasising that his government had no opposition to any language, including Hindi, the chief minister clarified that his party's stand was solely against the imposition of Hindi over Tamil. He asserted that those interested in learning Hindi were free to enrol in Kendriya Vidyalayas or attend classes conducted by the Hindi Prachara Sabha.

Critics of NEP 2020 also argue that the Centre's actions—or inactions—contradict its rhetoric on "promoting regional languages", citing its failure to recruit sufficient regional language teachers in Kendriya Vidyalayas and the lack of efforts to introduce South Indian languages in schools north of the Vindhyas.

Tamil Nadu's resistance traces its roots to the inflamed sentiments against Hindi imposition that shaped its Dravidianist polity over three decades in the mid-20th century. Periodic attempts to make Hindi a mandatory language in the state's education system sparked agitations in 1937-40, 1948 and 1965. The two-language policy—Tamil and English—was institutionalised as a response to these agitations, ensuring that Tamil students were not compelled to learn Hindi. The DMK has long argued that this policy has enabled TN's students to excel and be competitive globally without the added burden of a third language.

Escalating the stand-off, the Centre has withheld Rs 2,152 crore under the Samagra Shiksha scheme, penalising Tamil Nadu for refusing to join the PM SHRI initiative, a centrally sponsored programme to upgrade 14,500 model schools with a focus on holistic, inclusive and sustainable education. While Tamil Nadu is willing to participate in PM SHRI, it rejects the non-negotiable condition of implementing NEP 2020, which it calls a Trojan horse for Hindi.

Tamil Nadu accuses the BJP-led Union government of using financial coercion to force NEP compliance, a tactic the DMK decries as an assault on state autonomy. "The Centre says Tamil Nadu will get Rs 2,000 crore if the state implements the NEP. I wish to say that we will not agree to the NEP even if the

WHAT NEP SAYS ON THREE LANGUAGES

- **The three-language formula will be implemented while keeping in mind the constitutional provisions, aspirations of the people, regions and the Union, and the need to promote multilingualism and national unity**
- **There will be a greater flexibility in the three-language formula, and no language will be imposed on any state**
- **The three languages learned by children will be the choices of states, regions and students themselves, so long as at least two of the three languages are native to India**

TAMIL NADU'S FEARS

- **The three-language formula of the NEP is a covert attempt to introduce/ impose Hindi over Tamil through the backdoor**
- **Introduction of common entrance exams for undergraduate admissions will be disadvantageous to underprivileged students**
- **The non-negotiable condition of implementing NEP 2020 in PM SHRI schools is also a plan to impose Hindi**

TAMIL NADU SLAMS THREE-LANGUAGE NORM AS TROJAN HORSE FOR HINDI, THE BJP CALLS TN'S STANCE 'POLITICAL'